

# Work

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## Introduction

We spend a lot of our lives at work. Our occupation is so named because it occupies much of our time, energy and attention. We spent much of our early lives preparing for it. It is how many identify us: What do you do? It's how many judge us. It's how many of us find identity in this world. It's the first thing that many of us give attention to in the morning once we are ready for the day and the last thing that some of us give attention to at night. Many of us rely on work to provide for our wants and needs, for our families and our future. It's our contribution to responsibility and citizenship.

In Christian circles, work is often spiritualized as vocation or calling. Christian vocation in work is discussed in terms of how your talent and abilities can benefit others in the world. Calling is discussed with regard to what you sense God leading you to do, whether or not it is spiritual or secular in nature.

How do we really know we are doing God's will and not our own though? Because it feels right? Because we are passionate about it? Because God has opened a door to it for us? Because what we do benefits others? Because God gave us this dream, then worked it out?

If we trust the Bible as God's word, we should examine what it says about work, vocation and calling. That's what this book does via a word study approach. Those words are called out in the chapters that follow. We start by looking at God's work, then our work.

## God's work

God's work is creative. His creative work is to call (kaleō, G2564) those things which be not as though they were (Romans 4:17). God works through His word, which is as an incorruptible seed (1 Peter 1:23). Once spoken, it will do what it was sent out to do (Isaiah 55:11).

God's work in the beginning of the world was to lay the foundation of the earth. The heavens are the works of His hands (Hebrews 1:10). By faith He speaks, and He quickens (gives life to) the dead (Romans 4:17). He made male and female in His image, blessed them, and gave them dominion over the earth (Genesis 1:26-28, Mark 10:6, Hebrews 2:7).

God's faith has brought all good things into existence, for He is good (James 1:17).

Jesus' work (ergazomai, G2038) was the work (ergon, G2041) of the Father (John 4:34, John 5:17, John 9:4), so we saw more of God's work in Christ's ministry. God with Him, Jesus' work was to testify to truth (John 18:37), to do good and heal all those oppressed of the devil (Matthew 11:2; John 5:20,26, Acts 10:38, 1 John 3:8), to set an example of what it was to do God's work in this world (John 9:3-4, John 17:4), to make disciples (Luke 9:1-10:19), to unlock the fullness of salvation through His atonement, and to command us to do God's word as He did it (Matthew 28:18-20).

Now His work is to prepare a place for us who continue His work (John 14:3). His work is to intercede for us, doing whatever we ask in His name, that the Father may be glorified in Him (John 14:12-14).

## Man's work

At the dawn of creation, mankind was given dominion over the earth and blessed to be fruitful and multiply (Genesis 1:26-29). God was providing for them out of His abundance, so this wasn't work.

The toil of work began at the fall of man, for the ground was cursed because of his sin (Genesis 3:17). Rather than God providing for man, man was left to provide for himself and his family.

This is still the case: we must provide for ourselves and any family for which we take responsibility. In the New Testament, the church was directed that "if anyone does not provide for his relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever" (1 Timothy 5:8).

The purpose of work is to provide for the members of our household. Further, for the Christian, it is "so that he may have something to share with anyone in need" (Ephesians 4:28) and to have a good reputation (1 Thessalonians 4:11-12).

The Apostle Paul said that those who preach the gospel should make their living from that work, although Paul did not (1 Corinthians 9:13-15). Paul was a tentmaker by occupation (Acts 18:2-3). He worked night and day so he could freely preach the gospel, sharing life with fellow believers; meanwhile, he did not want to burden them (1 Thessalonians 2:8-9). Paul also worked hard to set an example for the Thessalonians. He commanded that those who would not work would not eat. Some of them didn't work but were busybodies, so he said that all should work quietly and eat the food they earn (2 Thessalonians 3:8-12).

## Vocation

To modern day Christians, work, including work apart from the work of ministry, is most often looked at as vocation or calling, whether of sacred or secular nature.

The closest word used for vocation in scripture is klēsis, G2821, which also means calling. One passage that uses this word exhorts us as Christians to “walk worthy of the vocation wherewith ye are called” (Ephesians 4:1).

Even so, there are not different callings or vocations described, but rather just “the high calling of God in Christ Jesus” (Philippians 3:14).

The idea of secular work being done unto the Lord does not enter into description until the Apostle Paul addresses the bondservants who do not have the freedom to choose what they do. The bondservants are directed, “Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord not for men... You are serving the Lord Christ” (Colossians 3:23-24).

Unless you are not free to choose what you do, or unless you are paid to do exactly what God calls Christ followers to do, vocation and calling does not have to do with your work. Vocation and calling, as described in our scriptures, are not secular.

Paul said to the bondservants of his time: “Were you a bondservant when called? Do not be concerned about it. (But if you can gain your freedom, avail yourself of the opportunity.) For he who was called in the Lord as a bondservant is a freedman of the Lord. Likewise he who was free when called is a bondservant of Christ. You were bought at a price; do not become the bondservants of men” (1 Corinthians 7:21-23).

While the purpose of work is to provide, our calling in Christ is sacred in nature. There’s only one call that goes to all men and women, for God is no respecter of persons (Acts 10:34, Romans 2:11).

## Calling

As followers of Christ, our calling doesn't differ; it's not for some but for all. We are called to life in Jesus Christ and to the lifestyle brought about by Jesus Christ living in us.

We are called (kaleō, G2564) first out of darkness into light (1 Peter 2:9). All of our lives, speech, and deeds are to be exposed to this light, and are to call others into the light as well. We are to be light.

Ours is a heavenly calling (Hebrews 3:1) wherein we become sons of God (1 John 3:1); brethren of Jesus Christ (Hebrews 2:11), the Son of God; co-heirs together with Him (Romans 8:17). We are fully identified with Jesus Christ, and we have what He has.

We are called with a high and holy calling, not according to our works, but according to His own purpose and grace (2 Timothy 1:9); in Christ, God has given us a spirit not of fear but of miraculous ability, generous love, and a sound, renewed mind. With Christ as our guide, we are to be bold in the Spirit (2 Timothy 1:7-8).

God gave us His Holy Spirit so we would have His nature, holiness included. Cooperating with God's indwelling Spirit, we are called to live holy lives (1 Thessalonians 4:7-8, 5:23-24).

We are called to His glory and virtue. By steadfast faith in His promises, we are to become partakers of His divine nature (2 Peter 1:3, 2 Thessalonians 2:14). Faith is an action taken in trust of God. God is glorified when our character and nature becomes more like His.

Having received the imperishable word of God, we are called to the kingdom and glory of God, so we are to walk worthy of it (1 Thessalonians 2:12). His kingdom is His government. It's His rule. It's where His will is done. We are to see that His will is done in us and through us. This is what it means to walk worthy of the vocation wherewith we are called (Ephesians 4:1). We are to use our liberty to choose not the flesh but to choose God's government and rule (Galatians 5:13).

We are called not just as individuals but to one body, one Spirit, each with a measure of the supernatural gift of Christ from our Spirit (1 Corinthians 12:11-13, Ephesians 4:1-7, Colossians 3:15). We are called to this body, this church, His fullness through whom Christ operates in this world (Ephesians 1:18-23).

We are together called to follow in His steps (1 Peter 2:21), making our calling and election sure by the godly character we develop and the good fruit that accompanies it (2 Peter 1:10). Making us worthy of His calling, God fulfills every resolve for good and every work of faith by His power so the name of our Lord Jesus may be glorified (2 Thessalonians 1:11-12, John 14:12-14).

After our work together with God here is complete, we will be called to eternity where we will be made complete (1 Peter 5:10). There, we will be blessed to be called to the marriage supper of the Lamb (Revelation 19:6-9).



## Call to work

Our calling does include work (ergon, G2041). Scripture says much about what our work is to be.

In particular, we are responsible and empowered to do good to all, especially those in the household of faith (Galatians 6:10). First, God has made us responsible for doing good. Made in God's image, we have been set over the works of God's hands (Hebrews 2:7-8). As such, God chooses to act through us. We are created in Christ Jesus for good works prepared in advance for us (Ephesians 2:10). If we do not do good to those God has placed into our lives, good will not be done. Therefore to him that knows to do good, and does not do it, to him it is sin (James 4:17).

Second, we are empowered to do good. It was the Spirit who anointed and lived in Jesus that gave Him words to speak and empowered His miracles. The same Spirit in Jesus Christ abides in us (Romans 8:11), if we are obedient disciples (Acts 5:32), and will similarly empower the ministry of Christ that we take the responsibility to carry on (John 14:10-14, 2 Corinthians 5:17-6:1, Hebrews 13:21). It is the living word of God in us that furnishes us for good works and completes us (2 Timothy 3:17, Hebrews 4:12). Christ in us, we are to work righteousness, obtain God's promises, and overcome by faith (Acts 10:35, Hebrews 11:33). We are empowered by doing our good works in Jesus' name (John 14: 10-14, Colossians 3:17).

To be doers of good is to be a doer of God's work in the world (James 1:25), for He is good (Mark 10:18). The indwelling Spirit of God makes us zealous of good works (Titus 2:14), causing us to richly abound in every good work, the work of the Lord (1 Corinthians 15:58, 2 Corinthians 9:8, Colossians 1:10, 1 Timothy 6:18). Love is not a feeling, but, rather, love is in deed and in action (James 2:8-9, 1 John 3:18, 3 John 1:5-6). We are each to get up, get out there, and use what God gave us, bringing increase to God (Matthew 25:16). We are the light of the world. We are not to hide this light, but to put it on full display before others. We are each to proclaim the gospel, doing the work of an evangelist (Acts 13:2, 2 Timothy 4:5). We are to build God's church (1 Corinthians 9:1, Ephesians 4:12). We are to minister and serve. Others are to see our good works and give glory to our heavenly Father (Matthew 5:14-16). We are each meant to do good as Christ did good. We are also to provoke one another to love and good works (Hebrews 10:24).

## Makers and doers

In Greek, the word for make, author, and do is the same: poieiō (G4160). It describes our work as God's makers and doers. It describes how we are to occupy our time and what we are to create as disciples of Jesus Christ.

From the book of Matthew, we learn what it means to be makers and doers. As disciples, Jesus makes us into fishers of men (Matthew 4:19). As disciples, we are to do what Jesus says (Matthew 7:24, Matthew 8:9). We are to do good to all, including those who hate us (Matthew 5:44, Matthew 12:12, Matthew 21:15). We are to give alms (Matthew 6:2-3). We are to take care of the least of these (Matthew 25:14). We are to speak to the mountains in the way of God's kingdom work and command them to move, as Jesus taught and demonstrated (Matthew 21:21). As good trees, we are to bring forth good fruit (Matthew 7:17-19, 12:33, 13:23). We are to multiply what God gave us (Matthew 25:16). As God's family, we are to do God's will (Matthew 12:50).

From the book of Mark, we learn what it means to be makers and doers. As disciples, we are to ask others what they will Jesus do for them and do it (Mark 10:51). We are to do good to the poor (Mark 14:7). We are to go out two by two to preach, heal, and cast out demons (Mark 3:14, Mark 6:30). We are to do miracles in Jesus' name (Mark 9:39), making the mute speak, the deaf hear, and the blind see (Mark 7:37, Mark 8:25). As God's family, we are to do His will (Mark 3:35).

From the books authored by Luke, we learn what it means to be makers and doers. Again, as disciples, we are to ask others what they will Jesus do for them and do it (Luke 18:41). As disciples, Christ the physician and miracle worker abides in us (Luke 4:23, Acts 2:22, Acts 6:8, Acts 8:6). His life and freedom overflows out of us (Acts 19:11-12). He speaks His words through us, and our hands are His hands. As we will others to do to us, we are to do that for them (Luke 6:31). As disciples, we are to do what Jesus said to do (Luke 6:46). We are doers of the word of God (Luke 8:21). To do His word is to do good (Luke 6:43), for God has nature good like His own. God does good even to those who hate Him, and we are to do the same (Luke 6:27). We are to be merciful as God is merciful (Luke 6:36, Acts 9:36), according to the example of the good Samaritan (Luke 10:37). Just as God welcomes all, we are to invite the marginalized to any feast we make (Luke 14:13). As disciples, we are commanded to give away all that we have (Luke 12:33). As those who have God's life in them, we are to bear fruit (Luke 8:8) that is worthy of repentance (or a renewed mind, Luke 3:8-9). God's true children bear worthy fruit, while those who do not will be cast into the fire. God's children seek to do all of God's will (Acts 13:22). It's how they choose to spend their time (Acts 18:23). They rehearse all God has done with them for others (Acts 14:27, Acts 15:4,12, Acts 21:19).

From the books authored by John, we learn what it means to be makers and doers. We no longer serve sin; but, instead, we destroy the works of the devil (John 8:34; 1 John 3:8). Our food is to do the will of our Father who sent us, and to finish his work (John 4:34,6:38; 1 John 2:17). In this, we do nothing of ourselves, but first we listen to our Father and His will. Then we

speak and we do what we see our Father doing (John 5:19-20,30; Revelation 2:5). In our lifestyle of loving obedience, we please Him who abides with us and works through us, doing the works Jesus has done and even greater works, that the Father may be glorified in Him (John 8:28-29; 9:31; 14:10,1-14,23; 15:14; 17:4; Revelation 22:14). Having been made righteous by the Word, our work is to do what is right (1 John 2:29; 3:9,22). In Jesus' name, we make people whole (John 5:11,15; 9:6). In Jesus' name, we serve all men (John 13:15,17). In Christ, God has made us kings and priests to reign over the earth (Revelation 5:10).

From the Epistles authored by Paul, we learn what it is to be makers and doers. We are to consider what will bring God glory and do that (1 Corinthians 10:31). This means doing God's will (Ephesians 6:6; Hebrews 10:36, 13:21). It means sowing to the Spirit, doing the good that the Spirit of God loves. We are to go good to everyone, especially to those who are of the household of faith (Galatians 6:7-10). Whatever good we do in word or deed, we are to do in the name of our Lord Jesus, cooperating with Him. We are to expect Him to work together with us, giving thanks to God and the Father for Christ's finished work (Colossians 3:17). We are to be steadfast, fully expecting to receive what is promised (Hebrews 10:36). We can expect to be equipped and made complete in every good work to do His will (Hebrews 13:21). His will for us is to be sons of God, conformed to the image of Jesus (Romans 8:29), walking as Jesus walked (1 John 2:6).

From the Epistles of James and Peter, we learn what it is to be makers and doers. As the royalty of God, we are to fulfill the royal/kingly law without partiality: Love your neighbor as yourself (James 2:8-9). God is not a respecter of particular persons, nor should we be. All are made in His image. God's love is not a feeling; instead, it takes action. At every opportunity to do good (James 4:17), we are to bear good fruit (James 3:12; 2 Peter 1:10), making wrong things right and bringing God's peace and salvation (James 3:18, 5:15; 1 Peter 3:11). Our focus is to be on doing good according to God's will today, not on what will come in the following days (James 4:15). This is what it means to follow in Christ's steps (1 Peter 2:21).

Made in His image, our work is creative as well. The Spirit of God will bring to mind at the right moment what we are to say and what we are to do.

### Judged for our work

Our daily works show who our father is, whether it be Satan or God the Father (John 8:39,41, Ephesians 2:1-3). Disciples work the work of the Lord (Luke 6:46-48, 1 Corinthians 16:10). Faith is not enough because faith is an action, and faith without works is dead (James 2:14-26). Good works follow from the good character (2 Timothy 2:21) that God develops in us (Philippians 1:6, 2 Peter 1:3-10), but God recognizes the works (Revelation 2:19). Works show a church living or dead. Their works should be full, consistent with what the fullness of the Spirit does (Revelation 3:1-2). Like Jesus, we can only work while we are alive (John 9:4). Jesus calls Christians to continue following Him in repentance (thinking in a new way) and do the first works (consistent with renewed thinking), or He will remove our candlestick (Revelation 2:5).

We will all be judged or rewarded by Jesus Christ according to our works written in the books (Revelation 20:12-13, 22:12). On the day of judgment, Jesus Christ will convince many of their ungodliness because of ungodly works and speech (Jude 1:15). Those who work iniquity will depart from Him at the judgment (Matthew 7:23). Lukewarm works are also unacceptable to Him (Revelation 3:14-21). He requires everything from us (Matthew 22:36-37). The earth and works (without eternal value) therein shall be burned up (2 Peter 3:10).

God will give to everyone according to their works (Revelation 2:23). God has no favorites (Romans 2:10-13), and our works follow us (Revelation 14:13). We are to work for things with eternal value. This starts with trust in and faithfulness to Jesus Christ (John 6:27-29). God is good, and so we are to work out good. As saints, we are to keep the very faith of Jesus, who lives in us, and we are to keep God's commandments (Revelation 3:7-8, 14:12). Work that is eternal will not be burned up by fire on the day of judgment; instead, it will receive a reward. This is the work built on the foundation of Jesus Christ (1 Corinthians 3:13-15). To he that overcomes and keeps God's works to the end, to him will God give authority over nations (Revelation 2:26).